

SHAKE UP Seoul Market Analysis

My read: Seoul is a strong market for SHAKE UP, but only if you position it as a gym revenue system, not a protein vending machine. The demand exists. The risk is location quality, refill operations, compliance, and whether gyms see it as passive income or just another machine taking up space.

I'm treating your uploaded iShaker-style proposal as the hardware/business reference point for SHAKE UP.

1. Market Attractiveness

Seoul demand is real

Seoul has about [9.58](#) million residents as of [Q4 2025](#), plus roughly 279,000 foreign residents

based on the Seoul Metropolitan Government's male/female foreign resident counts. That matters because your strongest early buyers are likely young Koreans, gym members, foreign students, expats, and fitness-focused office workers.

South Korea's health and fitness club market is estimated at \$4.75 billion in 2025, projected to reach \$7.64 billion by 2030, with a nearly 10% CAGR. That gives you a growing market, but it is still competitive and price-sensitive.

Protein and sports nutrition are also moving in your favor. South Korea's sports nutrition market generated about \$[1.08](#) billion in 2025, with sports drinks as the largest and fastest-growing segment. The protein supplements market alone generated about \$638.9 million in 2025 and is projected to more than double by 2033.

The biggest green flag: Korea's RTD protein beverage market reached ₩124.5 billion in 2025, with a reported 81% CAGR from 2020–2025.

That means the consumer is already trained to

buy protein drinks; SHAKE UP’s job is to beat convenience stores on timing, freshness, gym integration, and customization.



2. Competitive Landscape

Main competitors

Competitor	Strength	Weaknesses for them	SHAKE UP angle
CU / GS25 / 7-Eleven protein drinks	Everywhere, cheap, chilled	Not customized, not tied to workout moment	“Fresh gym-side shake in 20 seconds”

Online protein powder	Cheapest per serving	Requires planning, shaker, cleaning	“No prep, no shaker, no bag”
Gym cafes / manual shakes	Better experience	Labor cost, inconsistent, limited hours	Automated, no staff
Trainers selling supplements	High trust	Not scalable	Partner with trainers
Existing vending	Convenient	Usually snacks/drinks, not performance nutrition	Goal-based nutrition

Convenience store protein drinks appear around ₩2,900–₩3,900 in Korean retail examples, which sets your lower-end competitive anchor. You should not try to be cheaper than convenience stores. You should be more useful.

Also, convenience stores are actively pushing the category: ChosunBiz reported protein drink sales rose 31.2% at CU and 20% at GS25. That confirms demand, but also means you need a sharper reason to exist than “we sell protein.”

3. Best Seoul Customer Segments

Priority 1 — University-area gyms

Best zones:

Area	Why it works
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Area	Why it works
Sinchon / Ewha / Hongdae	Yonsei, Sogang, Hongik, language students, nightlife + fitness culture
Anam / Korea University	Large student base, gym culture, athletic clubs
Wangsimni / Hanyang University	Student + office commuter overlap
Konkuk University / Seongsu	Young consumers, trend-sensitive, good lifestyle branding

Yonsei reports 32,532 degree-seeking students on its main campus, and Korea University reports 32,179 students on its Seoul campus. These are not all gym customers, but the student density around those areas gives you strong foot traffic and repeat behavior potential.

Important: for school/campus placements, keep the menu safer. Protein, hydration, electrolytes, low-calorie options. Avoid aggressive pre-workout/caffeine positioning if minors or campus administrators are involved.

Priority 2 – Premium 24-hour gyms and PT studios

This is your best early launch category.

You want gyms with:

- 24-hour access

- visible reception or entrance area

- no existing protein bar

- members who stay consistent

- trainers who can recommend the machine

- willingness to revenue-share

SpoAny is useful as a market benchmark

because it claims 116 branches, 365-day operation, and budget-friendly pricing. That shows how normalized gym access has become, but large chains may be harder to close early because they need corporate approval. Your better first move is likely independent premium gyms, AbleGym-type locations, boutique PT gyms, CrossFit-style boxes, and body profile prep gyms.

Priority 3 – Office gyms / corporate wellness

Good zones:

Area	Why
Gangnam / Yeoksam / Seolleung	high-income office workers, PT culture

Yeouido	corporate workers, convenience-driven
Guro Digital / Gasan Digital	office density, tech workers, price- sensitive but high traffic
Pangyo later	not Seoul, but strong tech/wellness market

This segment may buy fewer pre-workouts but more:

meal replacement shakes

low-calorie protein

morning protein coffee-style drinks

afternoon energy drinks

4. Protein Source Analysis

Your early sourcing options

Source	Approx. cost	Use case	Notes
MyProtein / consumer bulk	~₩40,000/kg proxy from 2.5kg listing	Pilot testing	Easy, branded, but margin weaker
Korean online WPC sources	~₩13,000–₩32,000/kg depending product	Testing / small scale	Quality varies; verify food safety documentation

20kg WPC food- service bag	~ ¥ 23,500/kg based on Glanbia WPC 20kg listing	Best early operator option	Better unit economic s if documen tation is clean
20kg WPI bulk	~ ¥ 49,000/kg	Premium menu only	Too expensiv e for base shake unless priced higher

Danawa lists MyProtein Impact Whey 2.5kg at ~~¥~~99,900, or about ~~¥~~39,960/kg. At 30g powder per serving, that is about ~~¥~~1,200 powder cost per shake before cup, lid, water, flavoring, payment fees, cleaning, and gym share.

A Korean supplier listing shows Glanbia WPC 20kg at ₩470,000, or ₩23,500/kg. That drops powder cost to about ₩705 per 30g serving, which is much closer to where you want to be. A WPI 20kg listing at ₩980,000 equals ₩49,000/kg, so WPI should be a premium upsell, not your default base protein.

5. Price Per Drink Strategy

Seoul pricing recommendation

Product	Price	Why
Basic protein shake	₩4,500	easy adoption, near gym drink price

Premium protein shake	¥ 5,000– ¥ 5,500	better margin, still reasonable
Pre-workout drink	¥ 3,500– ¥ 4,000	lower ingredient cost, high margin
Add creatine	+ ¥ 500	very high margin
Extra protein	+ ¥ 700– ¥ 1,000	strong upsell
Low-calorie / diet shake	¥ 5,000	same cost, better positioning

Your sweet spot is ~~¥~~4,500–~~¥~~5,500. Below ~~¥~~4,000, your gym share and fixed costs start hurting you. Above ~~¥~~6,000, you need premium branding, better taste, and a strong reason not to

just buy from a cafe.

6. Mini Unit Menu for Seoul

For the MINI unit with 4 containers:

Recommended container setup

1. Vanilla Whey
2. Chocolate Whey
3. Strawberry Whey
4. Pre-workout / energy blend

Better user-facing menu

Do not show it as “vanilla, chocolate, strawberry.”

Show it as:

Menu item	Actual	Price
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	ingredient	
Recovery Shake	Vanilla or chocolate whey	¥4,500
Lean Shake	Strawberry whey, low-cal positioning	¥5,000
Muscle Shake	Chocolate + extra protein option	¥5,000– ¥5,700
Performance Boost	Pre-workout container	¥3,500– ¥4,000

The machine should ask by goal first:

- 1. After Workout / Recovery
- 2. Before Workout / Energy
- 3. Diet / Lean
- 4. Muscle Gain

That will convert better than making people

think like supplement shoppers.

7. Location Scoring

Best first launch targets

Rank	Location type	Score	Reason
1	Premium gym near Sinchon / Hongdae	9.5/10	young, trend-sensitive, student + expat density
2	Body profile / PT	9/10	high willingness to pay,

	studio in Gangnam		aesthetic s-driven
3	CrossFit / martial arts / performance gym	8.5/10	strong pre-workout + recovery culture
4	University campus gym	8/10	huge foot traffic, but more bureaucracy
5	Office gym / corporate wellness space	7.5/10	stable traffic, lower supplement intensity

Intensity			
6	Low-cost chain gym	6.5/10	high traffic, but corporate approval + price sensitivity
7	High school / youth school	2/10	avoid pre-workout/caffeine, compliance headache

8. Business Model

Recommendation for Seoul

Start with owned machines + revenue share

Best pilot offer:

“We install SHAKE UP at no upfront cost. Your gym earns a percentage of every sale.”

Recommended split:

Stage	Split
First 3 pilot gyms	60/40 or 65/35 to close deals
After proof	70/30 standard
High-traffic premium gym	fixed rent + lower share
Chain operator	lease + supply contract

The reason: Korean gym owners are often cautious with upfront cost. A no-upfront model makes the sale easier.

9. Risk Analysis

Major risks

1. Gym closures and weak operators

Korea's fitness market is growing, but not every gym is healthy. The Korea Herald reported 553 fitness centers closed in 2024, up 26.8% from the previous year. That means you need to screen gyms carefully.

2. Convenience store price pressure

You cannot win on price. You win on timing, freshness, personalization, and post-workout

convenience.

3. Hygiene and food safety

MFDS has been actively reviewing and supporting regulatory changes around unmanned cooking/vending systems, including hygiene and safety management for automatic food preparation businesses. You need a local compliance review before commercial launch.

4. Labeling and nutrition claims

MFDS food labeling standards require nutrition labeling for calories, carbs, protein, fat, and sodium for foods subject to nutrition labeling, and nutrition claims like “high” or “low” need to meet applicable standards. Do not casually claim “fat loss,” “muscle growth,” or “boost testosterone” on machine UI. Use safer wording: “high protein,” “recovery,” “low calorie,” “energy.”

5. Payment integration

Korea is strongly cashless. Simple payment transactions rose to 35.57 million daily transactions in 2025, and Naver Pay/Kakao Pay-type electronic financial service providers increased their share to 54.9%. Card + KakaoPay/Naver Pay support is not optional.

10. Launch Plan

Phase 1 — Market validation: 30 days

Target:

- 20 gyms contacted

- 5 serious meetings

- 2 pilot placements

- 1 university-area location

- 1 premium/PT location

You are testing:

drinks/day

flavor ranking

price sensitivity

refill frequency

machine downtime

gym owner satisfaction

complaints about taste/texture

Success threshold:

20+ drinks/day per machine within 30 days

Strong threshold:

30+ drinks/day per machine

Phase 2 — Seoul pilot: 90 days

Run 2–3 MINI units.

Best pilot neighborhoods:

1. Sinchon / Hongdae

2. Gangnam / Yeoksam
3. Wangsimni / Konkuk / Anam

Offer gyms:

- no upfront cost
- 30% revenue share
- monthly sales report
- free branded machine wrap
- staff gets limited free samples
- trainer referral QR code

Phase 3 — Scale: 6–12 months

Once you have proof:

- raise price from ₩4,500 to ₩5,000 where possible
- move from consumer protein to verified 20kg food-service WPC

add premium WPI option only in high-income gyms
negotiate 70/30 split
build a Korean landing page
target chains only after you have case studies

11. Bottom-Line Recommendation

The best Seoul entry market is:

University-adjacent premium gyms and PT studios, especially Sinchon/Hongdae first, then Gangnam.

The best product is:

SHAKE UP MINI with vanilla, chocolate, strawberry, and pre-workout.

The best price is:

~~₩~~4,500–~~₩~~5,500 for protein shakes, ~~₩~~3,500–

#4,000 for pre-workout.

The best money structure is:

You own the machine, gym gets revenue share.

The market is viable. The key is not hardware anymore. The key is location acquisition, food-safe sourcing, payment integration, and proving 20–30 drinks/day per machine.